In light of such measures Khan and Nisbet (2016) attempted to gauge young Pakistanis' response to state surveillance and censorship of the internet. They differentiated between heavy users of the internet, 'moderate users' – who use the internet 'several times a week' and light users – who use the internet 'several times a month or less'. Their research demonstrated differences in user opinion about government surveillance across these categories: 'In general, light users are substantially more willing to support government censorship and blockage of online content as compared to moderate and heavy internet users, especially considering sensitive political and religious topics' (2016, p. 7). However, in examining the perceived reason for government censorship, 'the plurality of Pakistani internet users (45%) believe that the government's primary motivation for internet regulation is to protect themselves from criticism while about one-third selected it was to curtail freedom of expression (35%)' (2016, p. 8). The level of trust in the government's regulation of the internet also varied across the different groups, indicating a diversity of opinion and trust in the government. While the internet provides a medium for greater connectivity, Durrani et al.'s (2015) research illustrates how for Pakistani youth 'greater connectedness may not automatically mean greater connection and better social cohesion but it appeared to give young people greater visibility and voice' (2015, p. 199). For Durrani et al. (2015) young people's experiences with social media and its relation to society, in particular the idea of 'social cohesion', are shrouded in 'fear' and 'excitement':

> There is fear that social media may be used to promote extremism among the youth; the state may fear that the social media may be used to subvert government position; the civil society may fear that Pakistan's Inter-state Intelligence may use social media to obtain personal information of the youth to spy on them; some elements in the society fear that social media may promote blasphemous material against Islam and youth may fear harassment and bullying online. (Durrani et al. 2015, pp. 197–8)

Given the implementation of PECA 2016, and the arrests of individuals like Taimoor Raza, this 'fear' is not irrational. Such arrests and detentions become especially life-threatening when individuals are accused of committing blasphemy.

## Silencing dissent

In January 2017 five prominent bloggers and activists disappeared, once again abducted by '*namaloom afraad*', only later was it discovered that they had